

the after-holiday sales.” Sales deserve their own dedicated section in this book, and they will get it, but in the meantime, understand that sales are cyclical. It is extremely rare for an item to only go on sale once or even twice a year. Every time we get a good deal, dopamine releases in our brains and makes us feel smart. So, the next time a sale comes up, we want to take advantage of it so we feel smart again. Whether we need the product or not is of no concern to our brains, we just want to feel smart again. It’s that dopamine reinforcement that makes it important to avoid sales while on a no-spend challenge. Now if it’s something specific that you’ve been looking for for a while and it goes on surprise sale during your no-spend month, then sure, get it. But that scenario is far less common than we lead ourselves to believe.

“How do I get the most out of a no-spend challenge?”

So glad you asked. What we love about no-spend challenges is how customizable they are. There are so many ways to do one that results in positive change. But we get it, when there are too many options, deciding can be paralyzing. We’re not here to stress you out more, so here’s a flexible three-step method you can use to craft yours.

1. Prepare

Doing a no-spend challenge on a whim is setting yourself up for failure. While we don’t think you need to wait for the first of the month or even a Monday to start, some prep work will help you get the most out of the challenge. First decide when you’re going to do it and what you’re going to cut out. You can choose to abstain from all nonessential expenses or just the three to four things you know are your biggest triggers.

While we consider groceries essential, some people take the opportunity to stay out of the grocery store by using the challenge to clear out their pantry stockpile or deep freezer. Whether you’re planning to buy groceries during the challenge or not, make sure you’re stocked on necessities like soap, toilet paper, diapers, anything you use regularly. Again, you *can* buy